

Stage 1: Self-assessment checklist with countersignature

Applicant guidance: Before completing this form, please work through the screening flowchart available on the [ethics hub](#) to determine whether your research qualifies for a stage 1: self-assessment checklist with countersignature.

You must complete this form before commencing any data collection. Please fill out all sections, following the instructions. If the details of your research project are still being finalised, please indicate all of the possible methods, topics, participants etc. which you are currently considering.

Statement of Amendment

1. Is this application an amendment on a previous application?

Yes
☐

No
☒

If 'yes', please use your original application form, highlighting any new information which you are adding.

Section A. Research Details and Researchers

1. Full title of research	Cross-Cultural Ethical Frameworks for Commercially Available AI-Powered Digital Resurrection Tools and Digital Legacy Planning Education
2. Short title of research	Ethical Considerations Around AI Resurrection Tools
3. Student name and module name (if applicable)	Tulin Bayramoglu
4. Student university email address (if applicable)	tulin.bayramoglu@lis.ac.uk
5. Principal Investigator name (PI) / Student Supervisor	Waqas Ahmed
6. PI university email address	waqas.ahmed@lis.ac.uk
7. Funding source	none
8. State any conflicts of interest and explain how these will be addressed	I am Muslim, and I do not consider this a conflict of interest, but I state it here in the interest of transparency. The research is deliberately designed as a cross-cultural and multi-religious study: it examines Islamic, Christian, Jewish, Buddhist, Hindu, and secular perspectives on digital resurrection technology alongside one another, and the public facing digital legacy planning tool produced as part of this dissertation is built to be usable by anyone in the UK regardless of their religious or cultural background. My own religious background does not determine the research questions, methods, or the platforms/traditions selected for analysis, all of which were chosen on academic grounds set out in the literature review.

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	This disclosure is expanded on in the dissertation itself, which includes a dedicated researcher positionality paragraph (in the Methodology chapter, alongside the reflexive-journal safeguard described under Limitations) setting out my religious background and Turkish identity openly for the reader, as an additional transparency measure rather than as a limitation on the study's scope. I have no financial, personal, employment, or other relationship with any of the commercial platforms examined in this research (Replika, Character.AI, HereAfter AI, Project December, Seance AI), and no relationship with any organisation that has a vested interest in the outcome of the study.
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Section B. Supporting material

1. Please mark 'X' against ALL supporting material which you are submitting with this application, as relevant to your research. <i>Note: It is at the discretion of the supervisor whether you are required to submit any of these documents in order to get ethical approval for Stage 1 applications.</i> <i>For templates, please refer to the Documents tab in the Ethics Hub.</i> <i>Please name all supporting material with the corresponding letter from this list. e.g. 'A: Email to school to advertise the study'</i>	A. Recruitment material (e.g. emails, posters, advert text, what you will say to potential participants)	☐
	B. Participant information sheet (information for participants to read (or hear) before they agree to take part (e.g. written information or, if applicable, an outline oral information script).	☐
	C. Consent form	☐
	D. Media release form (for situations where you may be collecting video, photographic or auditory data)	☐
	E. Draft questionnaire or interview material (including survey questions, prompts, or topics)	☒
	F. Other (please describe below)	☐
	Survey: Cross-Cultural Attitudes to AI Resurrection Tools & Digital Legacy: An Exploratory Survey – Fill in form Since the survey is anonymous and hosted entirely online, consent is captured as the first screen of the Microsoft Forms instrument itself. The branching feature of this form does not allow for the participant to progress if consent is not provided.	

Section C. Basic Information

1. Provide a brief summary of the aims and objectives of the research, written for a non-specialist audience. <i>This should cover the questions it will answer, any potential benefits and what you will do to address the question.</i>	AI companies now offer tools that use a deceased person's messages, voice recordings, and social media history to create chatbots that can hold real-time conversations "as" that person. This research asks three questions: 1. what do the design choices, Terms of Service, and marketing of these platforms reveal about the ethical assumptions built into them 2. how do people's cultural, religious, generational, and value-based backgrounds shape whether they find this technology acceptable, comforting, or troubling
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<i>(Maximum 300 words)</i>	3. how can the public — particularly older adults, religious and cultural minorities, and people without existing legal protection — be better supported to plan for their digital legacy and to understand these tools before encountering them. The research matters because current law (in the UK and elsewhere) does not protect ordinary people’s data after death, and public awareness of the planning tools that do exist is very low. Fewer than half of adults in England and Wales have a will, and no existing public resource helps people think through what they want to happen to their digital identity, data, and potential AI simulation after they die. To answer these questions I will: 1. conduct a short, anonymous, voluntary online survey of adults (approx. 7–9 minutes) asking about awareness, attitudes, cultural/religious background, and current will/digital-legacy preparedness 2. analyse the publicly published Terms of Service and marketing material of five existing platforms 3. observe publicly visible discussion on four Reddit communities where people already discuss AI grief technology, without engaging directly with any user. All three strands are assessed against a five-principle ethical framework (transparency, consent, dignity, bias mitigation, data protection) developed from the literature. Alongside the analysis, I am producing a free, public-facing digital legacy education.
2. List all places where research will be conducted (including any other countries and online)	Online only.
3. Anticipated research start date	Start of secondary data collection/online research: 26/05/2026 Start of primary data collection/survey circulation: 22/07/2026
4. Anticipated research end date <i>(A maximum of 3 years approval can be granted)</i>	Dissertation deadline: 02/08/2026

Section D. Screening		
1. In reference to the screening flowchart, please mark ‘X’ against ALL items of the checklist which prompt submission of Stage 2 ethics, and for	Issue 1: Sensitive topics ☐	
	Issue 2: Confidentiality ☐	
	Issue 3: Secondary data ☐	
	Issue 4: Deception ☐	
	Issue 5: Foreign participants ☐	
	Issue 6: Vulnerable groups ☐	

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which you are unable to mitigate the risks.	Issue 7: Complex contexts	☐
	Issue 8: Adverse risks for the researcher	☐
	Issue 9: Adverse risks for the participants	☐
	Issue 10: Risk to the environment	☐
	Issue 11: Consent	☐
	Issue 12: Incentives	☐
	Issue 13: Misc ethical concerns	☐

Section E. Research methodology

1. Please mark 'X' against the methods that will be used in your research.

Ensure you address each method you will use in your participant information sheet, informed consent documents, and on this form.

Use of casual or local workers (e.g. interpreters)	☐	Audio recording of participant	☐
Interview	☐	Video recording of participant	☐
Focus group	☐	Photography of participant	☐
Participant completes questionnaire in hard copy	☐	Physiological recording from participant (e.g. EEG, eye tracking)	☐
Participant completes online questionnaire or other online task	☒	Taking a sample of blood or other bodily fluid from a participant	☐
Use of social media to recruit or interact with participants	☒	Participant observation	☐
Analysis of existing records or dataset	☒	Covert observation	☐
Participant performs verbal or aural task	☐	Systematic observation	☐
Participant performs paper and pencil task	☐	Observation of specific organisational practices	☐
Participant performs computer-based task	☐	Use of man-made materials	☐
Measurement/recording of motor behaviour	☐	Other (please specify)	☐
Experiment	☐		

2. Provide a description of the research design and methods, written for a non-specialist audience. In particular, describe clearly what participants will be asked to do.

The research is conducted entirely online. Before any substantive question is shown, participants read a consent screen confirming they are aged 18+, and understand that participation is anonymous, voluntary, and can be withdrawn at any point before submission. There is a single session: a one-off, self-administered questionnaire of approximately 28 items (all questions, apart from demographics, are skippable/optional), taking approximately 7–9 minutes. It asks about self-reported cultural/religious background, general technology comfort, awareness of digital resurrection/griefbot platforms, attitudes toward AI simulation, and current will/digital-legacy preparedness. Two open-text questions are included and analysed thematically. No standardised clinical or psychological scale is used.

3. Will the research include any audio, video or photographic recordings?

No

4. Biological sample handling

N/A

5. Please detail all expenses or gifts that will be offered to participants.

N/A

Section F. Participants

2. Does your research involve the collection of primary data from participants? <i>Note: 'primary data' refers to data you will collect yourself</i>	If 'yes', please fill out the rest of this section	Yes ☒	No ☐
2. Age range of participants	The questionnaire is open to anyone willing to participate, aged over 18.		
3. Will your research involve primary data collection from any vulnerable groups, i.e. people who may <u>NOT</u> be able to give free and informed written consent? <i>e.g. those under 18, prisoners, or vulnerable adults</i>	No		
4. Anticipated number of participants	Approx. 50 survey responses.		
5. How was the number of participants decided?	The sample size reflects what is realistically achievable through convenience/snowball sampling within a 72-hour collection window, due to time constraints regarding deadline, and is treated throughout as an exploratory pilot sample rather than a representative or adequately powered one. I have chosen this number without particular reasons.		
6. Inclusion criteria	Over 18 years old.		
7. Exclusion criteria	Under 18 years old.		
8. Please mark 'X' against all planned recruitment methods <i>Consider providing copies of all recruitment material as supplementary material to this application</i>	Poster advert		☐
	Flyer		☐
	Email circulation		☐
	In-person approach		☐
	Website		☐
	Social media (e.g. X, Facebook)		☒
	Snowball sampling (recruiting through contacts of existing participants)		☒

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	Newspapers	☐
	Research recruitment sites (e.g. Prolific Academic, Amazon Turk)	☐
	Existing departmental contacts or volunteer database	☐
	Other (please specify)	☐
9. How will potential participants be identified and approached?		
A weblink to the anonymous survey, together with a short explanatory message similar to that on the survey (explaining 'about' and 'consent'), will be shared through my own university network and personal/social network (WhatsApp, Instagram, LinkedIn). Recipients will be encouraged to share the link onward with others who may be interested (snowball sampling). Individuals may be approached directly, but never in-person.		
10. Will written informed consent be obtained from the research participants? <i>If 'yes', please the details below (Question 12)</i>	Yes ☒	No ☐
11. If 'No' please explain clarify why consent is not required.		
I will be using secondary, anonymised data for part of my project.		
12. For each activity or group of participants, explain how informed consent will be obtained from the participants. How will their consent be recorded?		
All participants complete the same single online survey. Consent is obtained via an online consent screen built into the Microsoft Forms instrument: participants must actively confirm (by selecting to proceed). Agreement to this screen is recorded automatically as the first response in the dataset; no separate paper or emailed consent form is used, and no name or signature is collected. If this consent question is not accepted, the form skips to the closing screen, so no questions are displayed and no further data is collected.		

Section G. Mitigations for various Ethical Issues

This section gives you an opportunity to explain how you will mitigate any ethical issues which your research may involve. Failure to satisfactorily justify these issues will require a Stage 2 application (which will take an additional 4+ weeks).

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ISSUE 1: SENSITIVE TOPICS		
1. Does your research cover (directly or indirectly) any of the following sensitive topics?	Yes	No
Death/Bereavement	☒	☐
Domestic violence/abuse	☐	☒
Mental illness/trauma	☐	☒
Eating disorders/body image issues	☐	☒
Graphic/disturbing images	☐	☒
Familial/partnership estrangement	☐	☒
Miscarriage/Abortion	☐	☒
Paedophilia	☐	☒
Physical illness/Bodily injury	☐	☒
Sexism/Misogyny	☐	☒
Sexual assault/sexual violence	☐	☒
Drug or alcohol use/abuse	☐	☒
Extremism/Terrorism	☐	☒
Hate crimes/Hate speech	☐	☒
Infertility	☐	☒
Physical assault/Physical violence	☐	☒
Pornography	☐	☒
Racism/Xenophobia	☐	☒
Violence	☐	☒
Other (please describe)	☐	☐
2. If you answered 'Yes' to any of the above, please justify why this is the case / why this is required for your research.		
Death and bereavement are covered indirectly rather than directly: the survey asks about general attitudes toward AI simulation of a deceased loved one, awareness of digital resurrection platforms, and current will/digital-legacy preparedness. It does not ask participants to describe personal experiences of loss, name a specific deceased person, or recount grief experiences. The		

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consent screen makes explicit that the topic of death/bereavement will be touched on before participants proceed, and there is a statement at the opening and closing screens to signpost free bereavement support services available in the UK via website and phone 'if this survey brings up difficult feelings.

3. Please explain how you will mitigate the risks associated with research dealing with these sensitive topics.

Informed consent:

Participants are told, before starting, that the survey concerns attitudes toward death, digital legacy, and AI simulation of the deceased; that their data will be fully anonymous; and that they may stop at any time as they withhold the right to withdraw at any time.

Support:

The participant information (shown before the consent screen and at the end of the survey) includes the relevant bereavement support contact (Cruse Bereavement Support website link and phone number), so participants have access to this information whether or not they choose to continue.

Sensitive approach:

Questions are worded neutrally and at the level of general attitude/awareness rather than personal disclosure. No question requires the participant to name or describe a specific deceased person or personal experience.

ISSUE 2: CONFIDENTIALITY

4. Will your research involve any of the following?

Yes

No

Data collection in a setting where it may be difficult to ensure confidentiality (of participation and / or participant data), e.g. if collecting data about a sensitive subject in public, or in a workplace setting

☐☒

Collaboration with an external stakeholder (organisation / company / business / employer / individual) who may have a vested interest in accessing the data you collect

☐☒

5. If you answered 'Yes' to any of the above, please justify why this is the case / why this is required for your research.

N/A

6. If you answered 'yes' or 'no' above, please explain what measures you will take to protect participants and their data with regards to confidentiality.

N/A

ISSUE 3: SECONDARY DATA		
7. If your project is using secondary qualitative or quantitative data, please provide details of this source of data. <i>Note: 'secondary data' refers to data collected or generated by someone else, obtained from a pre-existing database and / or a public source such as a social media forum or internet site</i>		
Platform documents The Terms of Service, privacy policy, and public marketing/homepage pages of five commercial platforms (Replika, Character.AI, HereAfter AI, Project December, Seance AI). These are legal/marketing documents published by the companies themselves for a general public audience, not data collected under any research ethics clearance. Each is captured as a screenshot and stored on the LIS affiliated organisation enabled One Drive folder (like anything else pertaining to this project (i.e the final writeup). Reddit posts: Publicly visible posts from four subreddits like r/grief, r/Replika, r/AICompanion collected under a predefined search-term list to be stated in the dissertation. This data was originally posted by users for ordinary public discussion, not for research purposes, and so was not collected under any research ethics clearance. Collection follows Reddit's User Agreement governing public content (reddit.com/policies/user-agreement). Only publicly viewable posts, accessible without registration or subreddit membership, are collected; no direct messaging, posting, or other engagement occurs. No names, usernames, personal details or similar will be collected or included in the screenshots. Research papers: Data and findings from existing research on this topic will be referenced as cited in the dissertation.		
8. If your research involves analysis of secondary data, do any of the following apply?	Yes	No
The data is NOT anonymised <i>Note: data which is NOT anonymised means that the dataset or archive includes ANY information which could be used to personally identify a participant or undermine their confidentiality, such as their name, physical address, email address, phone number or personal likeness (photo, video or voice recordings)</i>	☐	☒
The original data collection did not get ethical clearance (to your knowledge)	☐	☒
9. If you answered 'Yes' to any of the above, please explain how you will protect the integrity of the data in your research.		
Note: the data may not be anonymised as I, as the researcher will be able to view the usernames of individuals on these platforms however I will redact all identifiable information before including it in the final dissertation to ensure it remains redacted and anonymous for future readers. Also, I will only be using post available publicly for this netnotgraphy, of which the process, including data protection and ethics guidelines will be touched upon on the dissertation itself to ensure		

transparency.

ISSUE 4: DECEPTION

10. Will your research involve deliberative deception or incomplete disclosure?

Note: 'deception' involves giving false information or deliberately misleading participants. 'Incomplete disclosure' is a type of deception that involves withholding some information about the research hypothesis, aims, purpose of the research, or process. Deception or covert collection of data should only take place where it is essential to achieve the research results required, where the research objective has strong scientific merit, and where there is an appropriate risk management and harm alleviation strategy. Note: You may be prohibited from conducting your research if you cannot provide a justifiable reason for deception.

The study will involve deception or incomplete disclosure (e.g. I won't disclose the details of the hypothesis or purpose of the study in advance to the participants (for example, to avoid biasing the participants to give specific answers))

Yes

☐

No

☒

11. If you answered 'Yes' above, please explain how you will protect the participants.

N/A

ISSUE 5: FOREIGN PARTICIPANTS

12. Will your research involve collection of data from participants who could be in a foreign (non-UK) setting? (e.g. via social media or other online platforms where the location of participants is not necessarily known)

Yes

☒

No

☐

13. If you answered 'Yes' above, please explain how you will protect the participants.

Potentially. Because recruitment uses personal and social networks (WhatsApp, Instagram, LinkedIn) and snowball sampling, some respondents may complete the survey from outside the UK, but the demographics questions ask about their current country. Those participants will be protected in the same way UK participants will be protected regarding data anonymity etc. Explained in the consent section of the survey. The survey can only be completed in English.

Section H. Data Management and Handling

All information provided by participants is considered **research data** for the purpose of this form. Any research data from which participants can be identified is known as **personal data**; any personal data which is sensitive is considered **special category data**.

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Management of personal data, either directly or via a third party, must comply with the requirements of the UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR) and the Data Protection Act 2018, as set out in LIS's [guidelines](#).

Note that standard practice is for all data collected to be anonymised prior to analysis. In order for data to be anonymised under the UK GDPR, there must be no means of identifying any individuals (i.e. all personal data must be removed). If, at any point, it could be possible to use any reasonably available means to re-identify individuals, the data is in fact pseudonymised rather than anonymised. Circumstances where this is allowed included cases where participants have signed a media release form.

1. Please mark 'X' against the data you will collect or analyse for your research

Screening documents	☐	Audio recordings	☐
Consent records including participant name or other identifiers (e.g. written consent forms, audio-recorded consent, assent forms)	☐	Video recordings	☐
Consent obtained anonymously (e.g. via online survey)	☒	Transcript of audio/video recordings	☐
Opt-out forms	☐	Photographs	☐
Contact details for the purpose of this research only	☐	Information about the health of the participant (including mental health)	☐
Contact details for future use	☐	Physiological test results / measurements	☐
Field notes	☐	MRI scans	☐

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Task results (e.g. questionnaire s, diary completion)	☐	IP addresses	☐
Data already in the public domain. Specify the source of the data:	☐	Other (please specify)	☐
Previously collected (secondary) data	☐		
Bank details for payment	☐		
2. How and where will each type of data be stored whilst the research is ongoing (until the end of all participant involvement)? List each type of data selected above, and explain how each will be physically transferred (including movement / sharing of audio files, paper records, electronic downloads etc.) from where it is collected to a suitable storage site (LIS-provided OneDrive storage)). Do not store unencrypted data in freely available cloud services or unprotected USB drives. Survey responses: collected within Microsoft Forms under the LIS Microsoft 365 researcher account, then exported and stored as a password-protected file on LIS-provided OneDrive storage. Secondary data captures (ToS screenshots, netnography extracts/coding sheets, survey result summary): downloaded/recorded at the point of collection and stored in LIS-provided OneDrive storage, organised by type, as password-protected files.			
3. Will you use a unique participant number on research data instead of participant name? Please provide the details below. Yes. The participant will be asked to create a personal, unique and non-identifiable code so that if they wish to withdraw at any time, I can facilitate this by locating their code and deleting their response securely. Otherwise, I would have no way of identifying their survey response or tracking it down.			
4. Who will have access to the research data? Researchers listed on this form will have access to the research data. This consists of the student researcher and the principal investigator (supervisor).			
5. If research data is to be shared with another organisation / individual, how will it be transferred / disclosed securely? No raw data will be shared externally. Any written outputs shared with third parties (e.g. examiners, potential publishers) will contain only aggregated, anonymised findings, and particular care will be taken to ensure no individual can be identified.			

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6. When and how will identifiable data (including audio / video recordings & photos) be destroyed or deleted?

N.B. If any identifiable data will be retained beyond the end of the study and/or indefinitely, please state what data this is, and the reasons for retention (e.g. contact details for future studies; photos used in publication). This must be clearly stated on participant information, and specific consent obtained via a media release form.

N/A as no identifiable data will be collected or stored.

Section I. Publication and Dissemination of Results

1. How will you disseminate and feedback project outcomes at the end of the research?

Results will be reported in the MASc dissertation submitted to LIS. Depending on outcome and supervisor guidance, findings may also be shared via an open-access institutional repository, and/or adapted for a future conference presentation or journal submission. No individual feedback loop to survey respondents is planned, since responses are anonymous and no contact details are collected; aggregate findings may be made available publicly (e.g. via the dissertation or the accompanying digital legacy education website) for anyone, including participants, to read. This has not been considered in further depth personally or with guidance of supervisor at this time.

2. Are there any specific groups or individuals who are likely to be harmed by the dissemination of the results of the study?

Yes

☐

No

☒

3. If you marked 'yes' above, please provide details, and explain how you plan to mitigate possible harm.

N/A

Section J. Declarations

1. Declaration by researcher:

The above checklist provides a full and accurate description of my proposed research. I have read and understood the School's Research Ethics Policy and Procedure and the questions in the checklist above, and I confirm that (*tick one*):

There are no ethical issues raised by the research.

☐

The research may raise some ethical issues, but adequate safeguards will be put in place.

☒

I understand that if my research plans change in a way that introduces new risks or ethical issues, or renders the proposed safeguards ineffective, I will be required to submit a new checklist.

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Signature	TULIN BAYRAMOGLU
Name	Tulin Bayramoglu
Date	21/07/2026
2. Declaration by countersignatory* (supervisor or module lead):	
I have read and understood the above research proposal and in my professional opinion:	
There are no ethical issues raised by the research.	☐
The research may raise some ethical issues, but adequate safeguards will be put in place.	☒
The research requires an Ethical Review by the Research Ethics Panel <i>(if so please request the applicant fill out the information outlined in the Stage 2 Ethical Review asap).</i>	☐
I require further information or clarification before making a decision on this application.	☐
I prohibit the applicant from initiating research for this project due to substantive ethical concerns.	☐
Signature	WAQAS AHMED
Name	Waqas Ahmed
Date	26/07/2026

**Note to countersigner: Please save the signed version of this checklist, and be prepared to make it available to the Ethics Lead, and / or the Director of Teaching and Learning or their nominee if requested.*